

Zotac GeForce GTX 280 AMP!

The New Big Daddy

The GeForce 9 had a really short stay and NVIDIA has released the GTX 280, around the same time that ATI launched their first card.

Zotac was the first to send us their over-clocked version of the GTX 280 that they proudly call the GTX 280 AMP! These new cards are crossing uncharted territories. The Zotac GTX 280 AMP! runs at a core speed of 700 MHz instead of the default 602 MHz. Most numbers on the new card have been doubled from what was on the last 9800GTX. The memory bandwidth has been increased to 512 bit and there is 1 GB of memory on the card. An 8-pin and 6-pin power connector is required to power the GTX 280 AMP!

It's just not all about the numbers. The GTX 280 absolutely destroys all previous records held by single cards. To give you an idea, the Zotac GTX 280 AMP! is

about 50 to 75 per cent faster than the colossal 8800 Ultra in most benchmarks. For example, in one of our tests, the 8800 Ultra scores around 100 fps in *Prey* at 1920 x 1200 with maximum detail and 4x anti-aliasing and 8x anisotropic filtering turned on. The GTX 280 AMP! beat it with a score of 173 fps. Even *Unreal Tournament 3* with all the settings turned up gave scores of 119 fps on the Shangrila map at 1920 x 1200. *3DMark 2005* and *2006* scores increased as well, but not to the extent of the real-world gaming benchmarks.

The card, in comparison, runs cooler than the 8800 GTXs, more so when compared to the 8800 Ultras. The cooling solution on the Zotac card is stock NVIDIA design. The card is a little less compact than the 9800GX2. It is lighter, but consumes over 300 W when on load. In idle, it drops to as little or lower than a 9800GTX card. A



power supply of at least 600 W is highly recommended to any future owners.

The Zotac GTX 280 AMP! is a great card and we're sure some of the non over-clocked versions are really good as well. It would be terribly wrong to say that the GTX 280 is not a good card. There's significant improvement in performance. There's one major problem right now, other than the high power demands—the price. The current price for

the Zotac GTX 280 AMP! is a whopping Rs 44,444, which makes it way over the top in terms of pricing.

As things stand today, the prices are exorbitant and with ATI releasing cards of their own priced at much lower prices offering better value for money, it's only a matter of time before the prices for the GTX 280 drop. GTX 260s are expected to hit the markets soon, so a little caution at the moment is recommended to look out for some extreme price drops.

Specifications

GeForce GTX 280 @ 700 MHz, 240 core processors, 1 GB GDDR3, DirectX 10 support, Unified Shader Model 4.0

Contact: ZOTAC International (MCO) Ltd.

Phone: +91-11-46665666

E-mail: sales@zotac.com

Web site: www.zotac.com

Price: Rs 44,444

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

ASUS Extreme Striker II

Expensive Enthusiast DDR3 Platform

The ASUS Extreme Striker II is the first nForce 790i Ultra SLI-based board we review this month. The board is targeted at the extreme high-end performance demanding enthusiast.

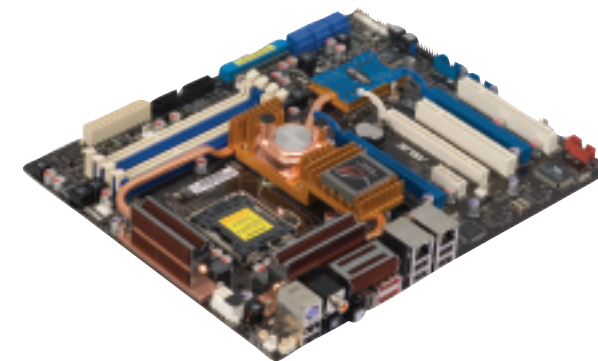
ASUS has implemented several design changes. There are loads of copper heat blocks and pipes. To stop the heat sink fins from scratching, there are small strips of flat metal on each of heat sink, which also gives them a very eye-catching look. There's even a glowing *Republic of Gamers* logo on the board. The main heat sink also has a provision to attach a water cooling kit—all the necessary connectors and washers are provided.

The focus on overclockers and enthusiasts is visible in

the CMOS. The first menu that opens has all the over clocking features and menus right there. Overclockers will love this board.

Other than a minor bump in the memory benchmarks, there is no other real improvement in the board. Game benchmarks also showed a 1 or 2 per cent improvement in *Doom 3*.

ASUS' energy saving EPU is built into the board, but there isn't the Express Gate features that allowed users to use the computer and the Internet, without booting into an OS. SupremeFX II is provided as an add-on module for sound that goes on to your motherboard. The box comes with *Company of Heroes: Opposing Force* and Kaspersky Antivirus.



The 790i doesn't offer anything special today and with DDR3 prices still not affordable for the masses, even the cheapest 790i boards don't impress large numbers. The ASUS Extreme Striker II doesn't give a bonus performance boost, but it does give you a whole

lot of flexibility. The features and quality of the board is top notch, but at Rs 27,000, it is ridiculously expensive.

Specifications

LGA 775 socket, Chipset: nForce 790i Ultra SLI, Up to 1600 MHz FSB, Supports up to 2000 MHz DDR3 RAM OC.

Contact: ASUS Technology Pvt. Ltd.

Phone: 1-800-2090365

E-mail: media_india@asus.com

Web site: http://in.asus.com

Price: Rs 27,000

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Kodak EasyShare V1073

Average Camera With HD Capabilities

With touchscreen devices getting cheaper and making their way into every possible gadget, cameras aren't being left out. Now, it's Kodak's turn. The EasyShare V1073 is an 11 MP camera with a 3x optical zoom.

It is thin enough to fit into a shirt pocket easily, but that also makes it a little difficult to hold with a single hand. The touchscreen also makes it difficult to use the camera with just one hand. The power and shoot buttons are positioned close to each other. The 3-inch screen doesn't have great quality—it is pretty difficult to use out-



doors even with the brightness turned up high.

The quality of photos isn't too different from its predecessors. The colours in the photos are pretty natural but the sharpness will likely be a little too much for most people's liking. There is image stabilisation, but images still end up a little blurry in well-lit sce-

narios. There is very little control given to the user, so there isn't a lot you can experiment with.

One of the key features is the HD 720p video recording resolution. A typical 25-second clip is 43 MB in size. The quality of the video clips is pretty impressive.

The touch screen makes a few other features easily accessible. For example, you can actually type in a tag for every single photo that you shoot using an on-screen keyboard. The high definition video recording is a feature that will interest many.

The price of Rs 13,999 is a fairly attractive price for a camera with these unique features.

Specifications

11.11 MP 1/1.63 in CCD sensor, 3x optical zoom, 3-inch LCD touch screen.

Contact: Kodak India Pvt Ltd

Phone: +91-9820510322

E-mail: kgdinkar@gmail.com

Web site: www.kodak.com

Price: Rs 13,999

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Zotac GeForce GTX 280 AMP!

